

Ola Daily: a guaranteed seat to the station and on to work, on one monthly pass

A scheduled network of shared e-autos and e-rickshaws that connects India's "missing-middle" commuters to the metro, rail and bus lines being built, and stands in for the bus where there is none.

By Anushka · anushka00218@gmail.com · Independent product case study, October 2026

THE BET IN ONE PARAGRAPH

By 2035 India will have roughly **1,700 km of metro** and **600M+ urban residents**. Even so, most commuters will still be stranded on the 2–4 km between home and the trunk line. Today their way out is a two-wheeler, the vehicle behind **45% of road deaths**. I would not ask Ola to invent a new vehicle habit. I would ask it to **formalise one that already works**: the shared auto, which tens of thousands of drivers run informally today at ~₹10 a ride. It has no schedule, no safety guarantees and no legal right to pick up along the way. **Ola Daily** makes it **predictable, safe, legal and bundled with the trunk ticket** for **~₹12 a leg**. Target: **100M habitual commuters on ~1M vehicles by 2035**.

1 India in 2035: trunk lines built, feeders missing

600M urban residents by 2036 (40% of India), with growth concentrated on city edges ¹	1,013 → ~1,700 km metro in 2025 (23 cities, 11.2M riders/day) → 2035 at today's ~6 km/month build rate ² (my extrapolation)	25–30% of forecast ridership is what most Indian metros actually carry. Access is the bottleneck ³	13 vs 44 city buses per lakh people vs the benchmark. 400+ cities have no organised bus service ⁴
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I make three assumptions about the next decade and test them against today's evidence. **(1) Trunks get built and feeders do not.** Metro and suburban rail keep expanding. Buses, at ~2,500 procured a year against the ~41,500 needed, only reach the benchmark around 2047⁴. **(2) Small vehicles electrify fully.** 61% of three-wheelers sold in FY26 were already electric (830,819 units)⁵, and LFP packs cost \$81/kWh⁶. **(3) Cars stay rare and drivers stay human.** Under 10% of households own a car today, and even by 2050 car ownership only rises to ~57 per 1,000 people⁷. The Union transport minister has said driverless vehicles will "never" be allowed⁸. So the 2035 answer has to work with human drivers, small electric vehicles and public trunk lines.

2 Who I'm building for: the missing-middle commuter

Definition. Someone with **no car, no frequent bus**, and who is **unsafe or unwilling on a two-wheeler**, making a 3–15 km daily trip, often to or from rail. They make up the bulk of India's commuters:

- Rail riders beyond walking distance.** People tolerate ~20 min for first + last mile combined, and most station catchments exceed it⁹.
- Peri-urban and Tier-2/3 commuters** in the 400+ cities with no city bus⁴.
- Women, older workers and students** who won't or can't ride. In Mumbai, 45.4% of women walk to work vs 27.4% of men¹⁰.
- Today's walkers and cyclists** (23% and 13% of urban-area workers in 2011)¹¹, who will need motorised trips as cities sprawl.

The job to be done: "Get me to work on time, safely, every day, at a price I can sustain, without having to think about it."

M

Meera, 26 · Pune, 2035
Customer-success associate · ₹26k/month · lives in Pimple Saudagar, works in Hinjewadi Phase 3 · nearest metro 3.2 km away

Today: 12 min walk, 10–25 min wait for a shared auto that leaves "when full", then metro, then a 15 min walk in 38°C heat or monsoon. That's **~75 min each way** and never the same twice. Her family wants her to buy a scooter. She is scared to ride on the expressway service road.

What she'd pay for: a promised arrival time, a safe guaranteed seat, and one predictable monthly cost below 10% of salary.

Why it matters beyond Meera: commuting already takes 77 min/day for employed men and 67 for women¹². Only 20.6% of women do paid work on a given day vs 60.5% of men¹³. When Delhi made buses free and safe for women, their share of riders rose from 33% to 42%¹⁴.

HOW I GOT HERE

- 1 · Fix the 2035 constraints.**
Sprawl, metro growth, bus shortfall, electric 3Ws, human drivers.
- 2 · Find the biggest unserved trip.**
Not the long haul (rail is solving it), but the 2–4 km to reach it.
- 3 · Look for behaviour that already exists.** 100M is too many to change habits from scratch; formalise what millions already do.
- 4 · Test every option against "100M, daily, ≤₹15 a leg".** Most ideas fail on price or on fleet size (p.4).

🔗 WHO GAINS WHAT (details on p.3; my estimates)

- Rider** saves money and time: ~₹12 a leg, ~20 min a day back, a safe verified ride.
- Driver** earns ~₹1,550/day vs up to ₹1,200 today, with guaranteed peak pay, in his own vehicle.
- Ola** earns ~₹120/vehicle/day from app fee, battery swaps, kits and city contracts.
- City** gets fuller metros, fewer two-wheeler deaths, and feeders without buying buses.

3 The problem worth solving, and why it's big

Problem statement. The trunk line exists, but for the missing-middle commuter the 2–4 km to reach it is slow, unpredictable, unsafe or unaffordable. So they turn down the job, walk for an hour, or buy the most dangerous vehicle on the road.

PUBLIC MONEY LEFT IDLE

Metros cost lakhs of crores and run at 25–30% of forecast, partly because of the access trip³. Each feeder rider is a near-free extra fare for the trunk line.

LIVES

172,890 road deaths in 2023, **44.8% of them two-wheeler users**, up from ~30% in 2014. Deaths in cars, buses and autos fell over the same period¹⁵. The default "upgrade" from walking is the deadliest one.

JOB AND TIME

Bengaluru drivers lost 168 rush-hour hours in 2025 at 16.6 km/h¹⁶. A Delhi Metro commute already cost an unskilled worker 22% of income in 2018, against a 10–15% affordability norm¹⁷.

The insight: India already has the product, informally

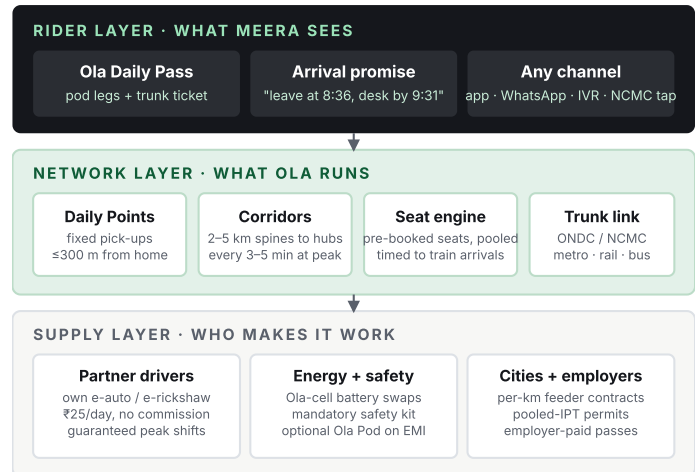
The **shared auto** is the country's real mass last-mile system. Chennai alone runs ~61,000 share autos at ~₹10 a stop¹⁸. In Delhi, shared autos and e-rickshaws carry 35% of metro last-mile trips, and riders spend just ₹6–13 a leg⁹. It survives without venture subsidy. But it fails the daily commuter in five ways:

- **No schedule.** It leaves "when full", so waits are unpredictable.
- **No safety layer.** Drivers are unverified, there's no tracking, and there's no recourse.
- **Illegal by design.** It runs on contract-carriage permits, so picking up mid-route draws ₹300–500 fines¹⁸.
- **Open vehicle** in 40°C heat and monsoon rain.
- **No connection to the trunk.** It's a separate cash payment with no timed transfer.

So the product is not a new vehicle. It is the missing layer:

scheduling, safety, legality and integration on top of vehicles, drivers and a behaviour Indians already have.

What we build: three layers



4 The product decisions that make it work

a Corridors, not door-to-door. 📞 MY CALL

Riders walk ≤300 m (~4 min) to a Daily Point. Pods run fixed 2–5 km spines to a hub, departing every 3–5 min at peak. I'm giving up door-to-door convenience on purpose, because at a mass price it doesn't pay (see the maths on the right).

b A promise, not an ETA. 📞 MY CALL

Riders book a slot once for the month and get a "leave by" nudge every morning. The seat is guaranteed and timed to the train. If the pod misses its promised time, the rider is credited automatically. Reliability is the product. Speed matters less.

c One pass for the whole commute. 📞 MY CALL

₹549/month buys 44 pod legs (~₹12.5 a leg). The metro or bus ticket is bundled at the operator's fare through ONDC/NCMC, and employers can pay for it as a benefit. Meera's total comes to ~₹1,650/month (~6% of salary), against 22% for some workers today¹⁷.

d Built for the next 100M, not the first 10M.

Booking works over WhatsApp and IVR in 12 languages, and payment by NCMC card tap or UPI. A rider can set up a monthly slot once on a feature phone and never open an app.

e Safety is mandatory, in a mixed fleet. 📞 MY CALL

No vehicle runs without the kit: camera, SOS, GPS trip-share, first aid, extinguisher; drivers are police-verified and checked monthly. Women can choose "**prefer a woman driver**"; if none is free, the app says so and offers the next woman-driven pod or a verified male driver. No women-only fleet: pink autos failed because drivers sat idle¹⁹.

f Bring your own vehicle. 📞 MY CALL

Existing e-autos and e-rickshaws join after verification, so no driver has to buy anything; "pod" means any Ola Daily vehicle. Seats are fixed from the vehicle's RC (e.g. 4 in an e-rickshaw) and never exceeded. An enclosed Ola Pod is offered on EMI only when a driver replaces an old vehicle.

Why corridors (my estimate): 130 km/day, 60% with paying riders

Door-to-door: 5 km trips × 2.5 riders → ~39 legs × ₹15 = **₹585/day** ×

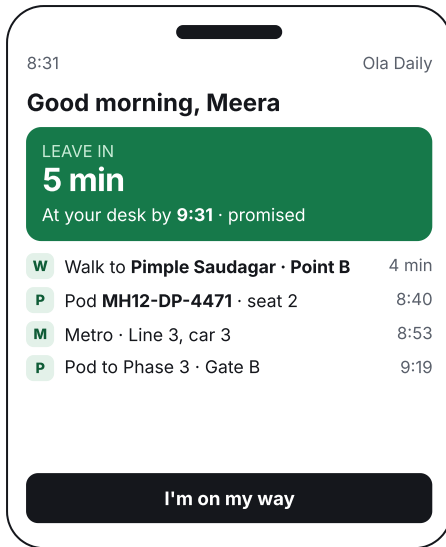
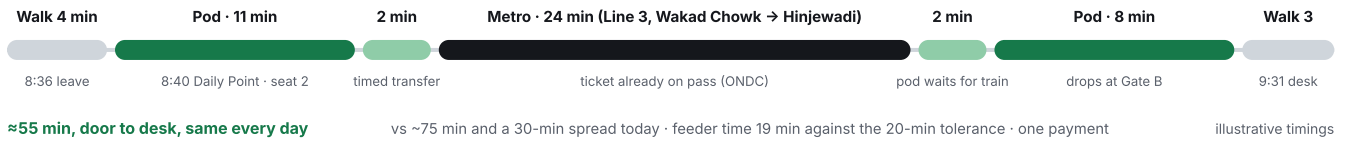
Corridor: 3 km runs × ~3.5 riders → ~91 legs × ₹12 = **₹1,100/day** in fares ✓ (full P&L, p.3)

Benchmark: Delhi e-rickshaw drivers report up to ₹1,200/day²⁰; autos run 100–160 km/day²¹

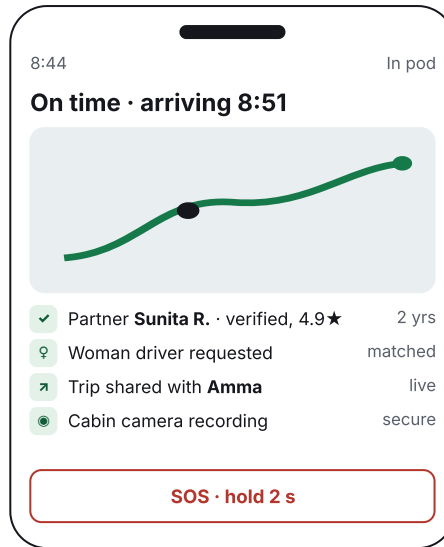
📞 KEY ASSUMPTIONS I'M MAKING (STATED EXPLICITLY)

① Metro keeps its ~6 km/month build pace, reaching ~1,700 km by 2035. ② Drivers are still human in 2035; no driverless approval. ③ City bus supply stays far below the benchmark. ④ E-3W costs keep falling with battery prices. ⑤ ~40% of urban residents commute daily (no post-2011 national commute data exists). ⑥ Ola raises funds for the battery network by ~2028. ⑦ States adopt pooled-feeder permits city by city. ⑧ Timings, prices, personas and the driver/Ola earnings are illustrative estimates; most vehicles are drivers' own 3–4 seat e-autos/e-rickshaws. ⑨ Rival app fees are from 2023–26 press reports; in-app prices may vary by city.

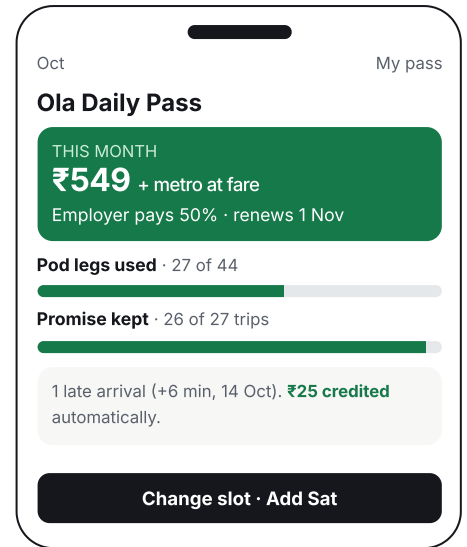
5 The core experience: Meera's Tuesday



Morning card. One decision per day: when to leave.



In-ride. Safety visible, never buried in a menu.



Pass. One cost; the reliability record is visible to the rider.

HOW THE DRIVER EARNS: RAVI'S DAY (my estimate)

Peak corridor fares (~91 legs × ₹12; he keeps 100%)	+ ₹1,100
Off-peak on-demand rides & parcel runs	+ ₹300
City per-km payment for off-peak coverage	+ ₹400
Battery swaps (electric, ~₹1/km, no petrol)	- ₹200
Ola app fee (GST incl., only on days driven)	- ₹25
Mandatory safety kit rent (camera, SOS, first aid)	- ₹15
Take-home	≈ ₹1,560/day

vs up to ₹1,200 for a Delhi e-rickshaw driver today²⁰, and he uses **his own vehicle**: no new purchase. Peak shifts carry a **guaranteed minimum**, paid from the route's total fares and the city's coverage payment, so one quiet trip doesn't dent his day.

HOW OLA EARNS: PER VEHICLE, PER DAY (my estimate)

App fee (no commission on any fare)	₹25
Safety kit rent (camera, SOS unit)	~₹15
Margin on Ola-cell battery swaps	~₹40
Operator fee on city feeder contracts	~₹40
Per vehicle · plus employer passes, Ola Pod sales	≈ ₹120/day

At ~1M vehicles ≈ **₹4,400 cr a year**, with almost no fleet investment. Ola Electric's role shifts from **selling vehicles to powering them**, which asset-light rivals can't copy.

Why the fee is only ₹25/day MY CALL: drivers run several apps and switch instantly. Autos pay Rapido ₹9–29/day⁴⁷, Uber ₹20–40⁴⁸, Namma Yatri ₹25⁴⁹ and Bharat Taxi ~₹30⁵⁰; Ola's own cab pass is ₹67²². Pricing at market keeps drivers; it's waived on days he earns <₹800, and the first month is free.

STRESS-TESTED: HOW A RIDE ACTUALLY WORKS · the rider questions I asked myself, and the rules I set

How do I book?	Set a recurring monthly slot (e.g. weekdays 9:00, Home → Metro) or a one-off up to the night before. Booking for mum too? Pick 2 seats; 2 rides come off the pass. Free cancellation until 10 min before. Board by scanning the pod's QR or tapping an NCMC card.	<i>A commute is a habit, so booking happens once, not daily.</i>
How long will it wait?	≤60 seconds. If live location shows you 1–2 min away, the driver holds; otherwise your seat goes to a waiting rider and you're auto-moved to the next pod . No-show = ride used; 3 in a month → standby.	<i>Like a bus: one late rider can't make three miss their train.</i>
Do pods come only if I book?	No. At peak, pods run a fixed timetable every 3–5 min, booked or not ; a booking only reserves a seat. Walk up, scan the stop's QR, pay ₹12–15. A pod stops only where someone booked, is waiting or wants to get off.	<i>Reserved vs general ticket, a rule Indians already understand.</i>
Route, stops, seats?	Never leaves its route or detours for anyone; drops only at stops on that route. Seats are capped by the RC; when full it skips pick-ups and the stop shows "next pod in 4 min".	<i>No detours = reliable arrival; no overloading, ever.</i>
What if a trip runs nearly empty?	The pod still runs its published timetable. The driver's minimum is paid from the route's total fares plus the city's payment , not trip by trip. Timetables are planned nightly from bookings and ride data, so quiet routes get fewer departures , and drivers not needed are released to normal Ola Auto rides .	<i>Crew paid by the route, not each trip; drivers never sit idle.</i>
Quiet hours (e.g. 2 pm)?	No timetable. Shared pod ₹15 or a pass ride (waits ≤5 min to group); "Leave now" ₹30 , the +₹15 shown upfront and paid to the driver; or a regular Ola Auto/Cab door-to-door at normal fare. 1–2 pods per route stay on pod duty.	<i>Cheap, faster or door-to-door, all in the same app.</i>
Late at night?	Drops at well-lit stops, trip auto-shared with family, woman-driver requests prioritised; night-shift hubs (BPOs, hospitals) get their own timetables.	<i>Safety rules tighten when risk rises.</i>

6 Why this and not something else

I scored six candidate products on what decides a 100M-user commute product. The scores are my own judgement 📞 MY CALL, grounded in the evidence in the last column. ● strong · ◐ partial · ○ weak · grey ○ very weak

OPTION	MASS PRICE (≤₹15/LEG)	CAN REACH 100M	PROVEN DEMAND	UNIT ECONOMICS	REGULATORY PATH	OLA EDGE	EVIDENCE AND THE DECIDING REASON
Pooled e-pod feeder network (chosen)	●	●	●	◐	○	●	Shared autos already move millions at ₹6-13 ^{9,18} . Corridor economics work, as the calculation on p.2 shows. Main risk: permits. Mid-route pickup needs stage-carriage-style licensing.
App shuttles / minibuses	○	○	◐	○	○	○	Shuttl spent ₹700.8 cr to earn ₹299.1 cr ²⁸ . Uber Shuttle exited India in 2026 ²⁹ , and Ola Shuttle itself shut in 2018 ³⁰ . Cityflo works at a premium ³¹ , with an average ₹88 fare ³² . At Shuttl's density, 100M users would need ~4M buses (my estimate).
Micro-car (own or subscribe)	○	○	○	◐	◐	◐	Ownership can't reach 100M when <10% of households own a car ⁷ . The Bajaj Qute sold 3,262 units in India ³³ . China's Wuling Mini EV sold 1.7M units over 5 years ³⁴ , which is big but nowhere near 100M. Adds cars to congested roads.
MaaS / ticketing app only	●	◐	◐	○	●	○	Gojek's transit usage rose 20× in a month after it integrated rail tickets ³⁵ . But ONDC already lets 30+ apps sell tickets, and government apps charge nothing ³⁶ . Good for reach, with no moat and no revenue. I keep it as the pass layer.
Door-to-door pooled cabs/autos	○	◐	◐	○	○	◐	Ola Share and Uber Pool were banned in Karnataka (2019) for running a bus-like service on taxi permits ³⁷ . Detours make arrival times unreliable, and ~₹585/day per driver at mass fares is below a living wage (p.2).
Autonomous robo-shuttles	○	○	○	○	○	○	Ministerial "never" ⁸ . Waymo does ~71k paid rides/day worldwide ³⁸ . Cheap Indian driver labour removes the cost case. I'd revisit for closed campuses after 2035.

Trade-offs I'm consciously accepting 📞 MY CALL

- **A 4-minute walk in exchange for a reliable arrival time.** Door-to-door is nicer, but it breaks both the price and the promise.
- **Scheduled over on-demand at peak.** This loses some spontaneity. In return, pods fill up and drivers earn a predictable income.
- **A small vehicle, not a bus.** Higher cost per seat-km, but it fits narrow lanes, launches cheaply in Tier-3 towns and is what drivers already own. Smaller e-buses don't save money: a 7 m bus costs ₹62/km vs ₹54/km for a 12 m one³⁹.
- **Depending on cities.** Partnering with governments is slower than pure B2C. But unsubsidised consumer shuttles have failed in every market studied^{29,40}, so I'd build the city contract into the model from day one.
- **Complementing transit, not competing with it.** Ola gives up long cab fares for a far larger, repeat daily-habit market.

BIGGEST RISKS → WHAT I'D DO

- Permits stall** (Ola Share's fate³⁷). → Launch only where permits exist (DMRC) and bring informal drivers in; squeezing them sank Manila's²⁴ and Nairobi's²⁵ reforms.

Empty seats off-peak. → On-demand rides and parcels; city per-km pay funds frequency.
- Copycats** (Rapido, Namma Yatri). → The moat is Ola's battery-swap network and multi-year city contracts.

One bad incident kills a habit. → Mandatory safety kit; incident rates published.

7 Why Ola, and what it must fix first

Ola is the only Indian player that owns **every layer of cost per seat-km**: rider demand, driver relationships, battery cells and swapping, maps and payments. Rapido and Namma Yatri can copy the app. They can't copy the energy network.

OLA ASSET (2025-26)	WHY IT MATTERS FOR OLA DAILY
Ride-hailing app, driver base, zero-commission model ^{22,23}	Day-one demand and supply. The driver model is already accepted.
Ola Electric: EV factory + 2.5 GWh cell line (scaling to 6) ⁴¹	A swap network serving existing e-autos and e-rickshaws, plus an optional Ola Pod. Claimed 10-15% cell cost edge ⁴¹ .
Ola Maps (in-house since 2024) ⁴²	Corridor design from years of trip data. No per-call fees at national scale.
Payments licence, ONDC participation	Bundling the pass with transit tickets and employer billing.

HONEST GAPS AND HOW I'D CLOSE THEM

Capital: Ola Consumer was marked at ~\$70M in 2026 with a Caa1 rating⁴³. → Asset-light by design: drivers bring their own vehicles, cities fund routes, and green-infrastructure funds finance swap stations.

Trust: 10,000+ complaints logged by the consumer regulator⁴⁴, and Ola Share and Ola Shuttle were abandoned before. → Publish service-level commitments and an on-time dashboard, and start with one city contract judged on results. **Share:** Rapido holds >65% of bike and auto rides⁴⁵. → Compete on pass reliability, not on single-ride price.

8 How it reaches 100 million

2027–29 · PROVE
3 cities · 25k
vehicles

1.5M users

- Delhi NCR (DMRC feeder permits already exist²⁷), Pune, Chennai
- Own e-autos join day one

2029–32 · NETWORK
25 cities · 250k
vehicles

20M users

- Pass bundled via ONDC/NCMC
- City feeder contracts
- Employer passes

2032–35 · BE THE BUS
Tier-2/3 · ~1M
vehicles

100M users

- Pods replace the missing bus in 400+ cities

Sizing check (my estimates): "user" = commutes with Ola Daily on ≥8 weekdays a month
100M users → ~60M ride on a given weekday → ~1.7 pod legs each = ~100M legs/day
÷ ~90–100 legs per vehicle/day (p.2) ≈ ~1M vehicles
E-3W sales are projected at 1.4–1.8M/yr by 2030²¹, so the national fleet will be >10M by 2035. Ola Daily needs ~10% of it.
100M ≈ 1 in 6 urban Indians (600M), or ~40% of an assumed ~250M non-car commuters in cities and towns.

What must be true

1. **States license pooled feeders:** permits for fixed-fare share autos (Chennai's CUMTA has proposed this¹⁸) under the 2025 aggregator guidelines⁴⁶. *The biggest dependency.*
2. **The price holds at ≤₹15 a leg**, with the full commute ≤10% of income, even after the guidelines' 80% driver share and insurance costs⁴⁶.
3. **Cities pay for coverage per km**, not per rider, as Jakarta does²⁶, so off-peak service exists.
4. **Trunk lines keep growing** and ticketing APIs stay open, so the feeder has something to feed.
5. **Partners earn more than they do informally** (≥₹1,200/day).
6. **Women feel safe enough** to make it their default.
7. **Ola funds the battery network** and rebuilds regulatory credibility (an IPO or strategic partner).

9 How I'd know it's working

NORTH-STAR METRIC
Habitual commuters
MY CALL

Riders who completed their commute with Ola Daily on ≥4 of 5 weekdays this week. It measures habit, not downloads or bookings. Every failed predecessor had riders. What they lacked was repeat daily commuters at a sustainable cost. **Target: 100M by 2035.**

INPUT METRIC	WHAT IT TELLS US	TARGET / BENCHMARK
Promise-kept rate	Is reliability, the core promise, real?	≥95% of trips arrive within ±3 min of the promised time
First + last-mile time	Does it beat the tolerance threshold?	≤20 min combined ⁹
Seats filled per trip	Density, where microtransit usually fails	≥85% of RC seats filled at peak. US microtransit manages 2–3 riders/vehicle-hour ⁴⁰
Partner net earnings/day	Will supply stay?	≥₹1,200, above the informal benchmark ²⁰
Corridor payback	Unit economics without perpetual subsidy	Contribution-positive in ~2 quarters, as at Cityflo ³¹
Pass renewal · women's share	Habit and safety, from the rider's side	≥80% monthly renewal · women ≥42% of riders ¹⁴
Ridership uplift at served stations	Value to the city, which is why the contract renews	Measurable uplift vs unserved stations (today at 25–30% of forecast ³)

Guardrails: safety incidents per million trips · safety-kit uptime (100%) · woman-driver requests met · commute cost ≤10% of income · city subsidy per ride (far below US microtransit's \$15–43⁴⁰). **Kill signal for phase 1** **MY CALL** : if corridors can't reach ≥3 riders per trip and ≥90% promise-kept within 6 months, the model doesn't work and I'd stop before scaling.

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